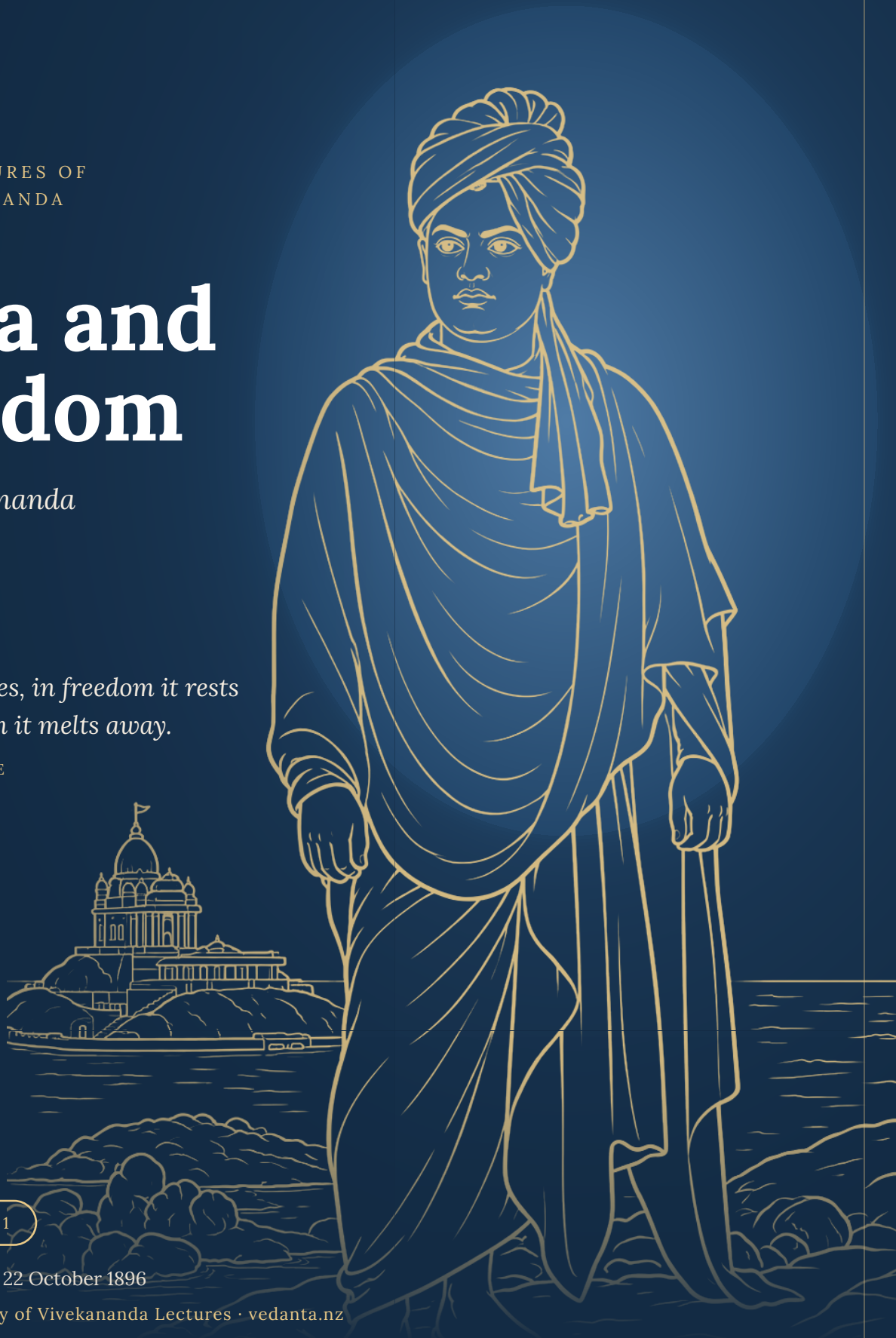
RAMAKRISHNA
VEDANTA
CENTRE NZ

01

VEDANTA LECTURES OF
SWAMI VIVEKANANDA

Maya and Freedom

Swami Vivekananda



> *In freedom it rises, in freedom it rests and into freedom it melts away.*

FROM THE LECTURE

STUDY GUIDE 01

Delivered in London, 22 October 1896

Ritam Courses · Study of Vivekananda Lectures · vedanta.nz

BEFORE YOU READ

Summary of the Lecture

In this London lecture Swami Vivekananda does not define Maya in the abstract. He shows it to us, in one scene of ordinary life after another, each ending with the same quiet refrain: "And this is Maya." Then he turns the whole picture around. The very struggle that binds us, he says, is the movement of every being towards freedom, and that freedom is not far away. It is our own nature.

1. **Maya is a description of our situation.** Life is a battlefield we enter weeping. Childhood dreams recede as we chase them. The senses pull us back like moths to a flame. The intellect meets walls of time, space and causation. We feel free and are shown, moment by moment, that we are bound.

2. **Even love can be bondage.** A mother clings to a child who ill-treats her and calls it wonderful love, though she cannot help it. Narada lives twelve years of marriage, wealth and loss in half an hour. Time, "the avenger," swallows saint and sinner alike.

3. **Two responses to suffering.** The "practical" response says: ignore the dark side and cover the wound with cloth of gold. Vivekananda says this must fail. The other response is a "still small voice" heard in every age and land, promising a way beyond Maya. Responding to it is what he calls religion.

4. **Religion begins with honest dissatisfaction.** Like the Buddha under the Bo-tree, the seeker refuses a life of patchwork and resolves to find the truth. The Katha Upanishad sums it up: Arise! Awake! The path is like a razor's edge, yet do not despair.

5. **Freedom is the golden thread.** Every religion, from the simplest to the most philosophical, points to a being who is free of nature's laws. The universe rises in freedom, rests in freedom and melts into freedom. Saint and sinner are both moving towards it; good and bad differ only in degree.

6. **The Vedantic answer: nearer, my God, to me.** Vedanta brings the free Being closer and closer, from heaven to nature to the body, until it is found as the Self of our own self. Maya never really bound us. When this is realised, the prison-house of the world becomes a playground.

Source. The Complete Works of Swami Vivekananda, Volume 2, Jnana-Yoga. Delivered in London, 22 October 1896.

THE SHAPE OF THE LECTURE

Outline

PART ONE

The Many Faces of Maya

1. Life as a Battlefield ¶1
2. The Ever-Receding Ideal ¶2
3. The Scientist and Insentient Nature ¶3
4. Moths and the Flame: The Pull of the Senses ¶4
5. The Walls of the Intellect ¶5
6. Free in Feeling, Bound in Fact ¶6
7. A Mother's Love ¶7
8. Narada Asks to See Maya ¶8
9. Time, the Avenger ¶9

PART TWO

Two Answers to the Human Predicament

1. The "Practical" Answer: Covering the Wound ¶10
2. The Still Small Voice ¶11
3. Religion Begins with Dissatisfaction ¶12

PART THREE

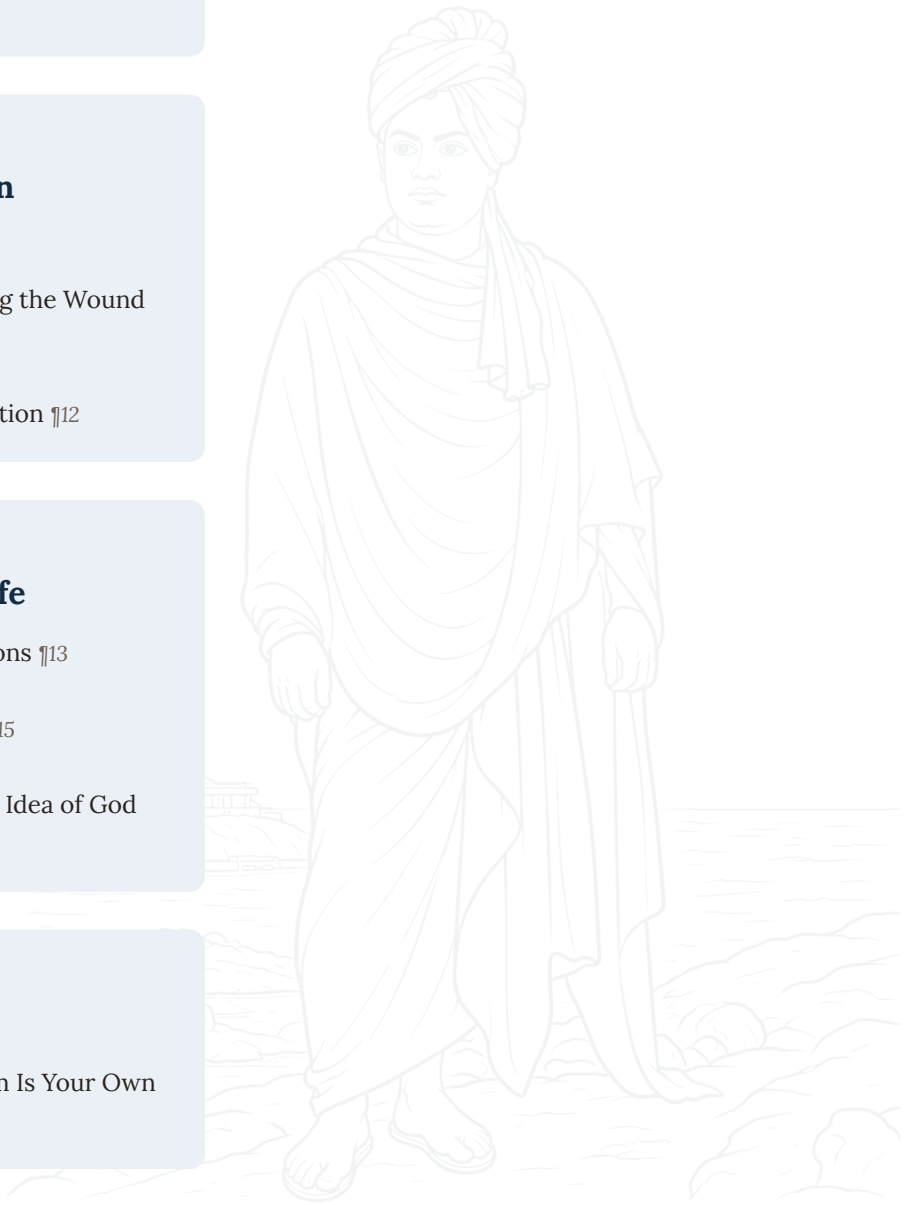
Freedom, the Goal of All Life

1. The Golden Thread in All Religions ¶13
2. "In Freedom It Rises" ¶14
3. All Creatures Follow the Voice ¶15
4. When the Scene Shifts ¶16
5. Beings Beyond Nature: How the Idea of God Grows ¶17

PART FOUR

The Vedantic Answer

1. Nearer, My God, to Me: Freedom Is Your Own Nature ¶18



THE LECTURE

MAYA AND FREEDOM

(Delivered in London, 22 October 1896)

PART ONE

The Many Faces of Maya

1

1 Life as a Battlefield

¶1 "Trailing clouds of glory we come," says the poet. Not all of us come as trailing clouds of glory however; some of us come as trailing black fogs; there can be no question about that. But every one of us comes into this world to fight, as on a battlefield. We come here weeping to fight our way, as well as we can and to make a path for ourselves through this infinite ocean of life; forward we go, having long ages behind us and an immense expanse beyond. So on we go, till death comes and takes us off the field – victorious or defeated, we do not know. *And this is Maya.*

2 The Ever-Receding Ideal

¶2 Hope is dominant in the heart of childhood. The whole world is a golden vision to the opening eyes of the child; he thinks his will is supreme. As he moves onward, at every step nature stands as an adamantine wall, barring his future progress. He may hurl himself against it again and again, striving to break through. The further he goes, the further recedes the ideal, till death comes and there is release, perhaps. *And this is Maya.*

3 The Scientist and Insentient Nature

¶3 A man of science rises, he is thirsting after knowledge. No sacrifice is too great, no struggle too hopeless for him. He moves onward discovering secret after secret of nature, searching out the secrets from her innermost heart and what for? What is it all for? Why should we give him glory? Why should he acquire fame? Does not nature do infinitely more than any human being can do? – and nature is dull, insentient. Why should it be glory to imitate the dull, the insentient? Nature can hurl a thunderbolt of any magnitude to any distance. If a man can do one small part as much, we praise him and laud him to the skies. Why? Why should we praise him for imitating nature, imitating death, imitating dullness, imitating insentience? The force of gravitation can pull to pieces the biggest mass that ever existed; yet

it is insentient. What glory is there in imitating the insentient? Yet we are all struggling after that. *And this is Maya.*

4 Moths and the Flame: The Pull of the Senses

¶4 The senses drag the human soul out. Man is seeking for pleasure and for happiness where it can never be found. For countless ages we are all taught that this is futile and vain, there is no happiness here. But we cannot learn; it is impossible for us to do so, except through our own experiences. We try them and a blow comes. Do we learn then? Not even then. Like moths hurling themselves against the flame, we are hurling ourselves again and again into sense-pleasures, hoping to find satisfaction there. We return again and again with freshened energy; thus we go on, till crippled and cheated we die. *And this is Maya.*

5 The Walls of the Intellect

¶5 So with our intellect. In our desire to solve the mysteries of the universe, we cannot stop our questioning, we feel we must know and cannot believe that no knowledge is to be gained. A few steps and there arises the wall of beginningless and endless time which we cannot surmount. A few steps and there appears a wall of boundless space which cannot be surmounted and the whole is irrevocably bound in by the walls of cause and effect. We cannot go beyond them. Yet we struggle and still have to struggle. *And this is Maya.*

6 Free in Feeling, Bound in Fact

¶6 With every breath, with every pulsation of the heart, with every one of our movements, we think we are free and with very same moment we are shown that we are not. Bound slaves, nature's bond-slaves, in body, in mind, in all our thoughts, in all our feelings. *And this is Maya.*

7 A Mother's Love

¶7 There was never a mother who did not think her child was a born genius, the most extraordinary child that was ever born; she dotes upon her child. The child grows up, perhaps becomes a drunkard, a brute, ill-treats the mother and the more he ill-treats her, the more her love increases. The world lauds it as the unselfish love of the mother, little dreaming that the mother is a born slave, she cannot help it. She would a thousand times rather throw off the burden, but she cannot. So she covers it with a mass of flowers, which she calls wonderful love. *And this is Maya.*

8 Narada Asks to See Maya

¶8 We are all like this in the world. A legend tells how once Narada said to Krishna, "Lord, show me Maya." A few days passed away and Krishna asked Narada to make a trip with him to-

wards a desert and after walking for several miles, Krishna said, "Narada, I am thirsty; can you fetch some water for me?" "I will go at once, sir and get you water." So Narada went. At a little distance there was a village; he entered the village in search of water and knocked at a door, which was opened by a most beautiful young girl. At the sight of her he immediately forgot that his Master was waiting for water, perhaps dying for the want of it. He forgot everything and began to talk with the girl. All that day he did not return to his Master. The next day, he was again at the house, talking to the girl. That talk ripened into love; he asked the father for the daughter and they were married and lived there and had children. Thus twelve years passed. His father-in-law died, he inherited his property. He lived, as he seemed to think, a very happy life with his wife and children, his fields and his cattle and so forth. Then came a flood. One night the river rose until it overflowed its banks and flooded the whole village. Houses fell, men and animals were swept away and drowned and everything was floating in the rush of the stream. Narada had to escape. With one hand he held his wife and with the other two of his children; another child was on his shoulders and he was trying to ford this tremendous flood. After a few steps he found the current was too strong and the child on his shoulders fell and was borne away. A cry of despair came from Narada. In trying to save that child, he lost his grasp upon one of the others and it also was lost. At last his wife, whom he clasped with all his might, was torn away by the current and he was thrown on the bank, weeping and wailing in bitter lamentation. Behind him there came a gentle voice, "My child, where is the water? You went to fetch a pitcher of water and I am waiting for you; you have been gone for quite half an hour." "Half an hour!" Narada exclaimed. Twelve whole years had passed through his mind and all these scenes had happened in half an hour! *And this is Maya.*

9 Time, the Avenger

¶9 In one form or another, we are all in it. It is a most difficult and intricate state of things to understand. It has been preached in every country, taught everywhere, but only believed by a few, because until we get the experiences ourselves we cannot believe in it. What does it show? Something very terrible. For it is all futile. Time, the avenger of everything, comes and nothing is left. He swallows up the saint and the sinner, the king and the peasant, the beautiful and the ugly; he leaves nothing. Everything is rushing towards that one goal, destruction. Our knowledge, our arts, our sciences, everything is rushing towards it. None can stem the tide, none can hold it back for a minute. We may try to forget it, in the same way that persons in a plague-stricken city try to create oblivion by drinking, dancing and other vain attempts and so becoming paralysed. So we are trying to forget, trying to create oblivion by all sort of sense-pleasures. *And this is Maya.*

PART TWO

Two Answers to the Human Predicament

2

10 The "Practical" Answer: Covering the Wound

¶10 Two ways have been proposed. One method, which everyone knows, is very common and that is: "It may be very true, but do not think of it. `Make hay while the sun shines,' as the proverb says. It is all true, it is a fact, but do not mind it. Seize the few pleasures you can, do not look at the dark side of the picture, but always towards the hopeful, the positive side." There is some truth in this, but there is also a danger. The truth is that it is a good motive power. Hope and a positive ideal are very good motive powers for our lives, but there is a certain danger in them. The danger lies in our giving up the struggle in despair. Such is the case with those who preach, "Take the world as it is; sit down as calmly and comfortably as you can and be contented with all those miseries. When you receive blows, say they are not blows but flowers; and when you are driven about like slaves, say that you are free. Day and night tell lies to others and to your own souls, because that is the only way to live happily." This is what is called practical wisdom and never was it more prevalent in the world than in this nineteenth century; because never were harder blows hit than at the present time, never was competition keener, never were men so cruel to their fellow-men as now; and, therefore, must this consolation be offered. It is put forward in the strongest way at the present time; but it fails, as it always must fail. We cannot hide a carrion with roses; it is impossible. It would not avail long; for soon the roses would fade and the carrion would be worse than ever before. So with our lives. We may try to cover our old and festering sores with cloths of gold, but there comes a day when the cloth of gold is removed and the sore in all its ugliness is revealed.

11 The Still Small Voice

¶11 Is there no hope then? True it is that we are all slaves of Maya, born in Maya and live in Maya. Is there then no way out, no hope? That we are all miserable, that this world is really a prison, that even our so-called trailing beauty is but a prison-house and that even our intellects and minds are prison-houses, have been known for ages upon ages. There has never been a man, there has never been a human soul, who has not felt this sometime or other, however he may talk. And the old people feel it most, because in them is the accumulated experience of a whole life, because they cannot be easily cheated by the lies of nature. Is there no way out? We find that with all this, with this terrible fact before us, in the midst of sorrow and suffering, even in this world where life and death are synonymous, even here, there is a still small voice that is ringing through all ages, through every country and in every heart: "This My Maya is divine, made up of qualities and very difficult to cross. Yet those that come unto

Me, cross the river of life." "Come unto Me all ye that labour and are heavy laden and I will give you rest." This is the voice that is leading us forward. Man has heard it and is hearing it all through the ages. This voice comes to men when everything seems to be lost and hope has fled, when man's dependence on his own strength has been crushed down and everything seems to melt away between his fingers and life is a hopeless ruin. Then he hears it. This is called religion.

12 Religion Begins with Dissatisfaction

¶12 On the one side, therefore, is the bold assertion that this is all nonsense, that this is Maya, but along with it, there is the most hopeful assertion that beyond Maya, there is a way out. On the other hand, practical men tell us, "Don't bother your heads about such nonsense as religion and metaphysics. Live here; this is a very bad world indeed, but make the best of it." Which put in plain language means, live a hypocritical, lying life, a life of continuous fraud, covering all the sores in the best way you can. Go on putting patch after patch, until everything is lost and you are a mass of patchwork. This is what is called practical life. Those that are satisfied with this patchwork will never come to religion. Religion begins with a tremendous dissatisfaction with the present state of things, with our lives and a hatred, an intense hatred, for this patching up of life, an unbounded disgust for fraud and lies. He alone can be religious who dares say, as the mighty Buddha once said under the Bo-tree, when this idea of practicality appeared before him and he saw that it was nonsense and yet could not find a way out. When the temptation came to him to give up his search after truth, to go back to the world and live the old life of fraud, calling things by wrong names, telling lies to oneself and to everybody, he, the giant, conquered it and said, "Death is better than a vegetating ignorant life; it is better to die on the battle-field than to live a life of defeat." This is the basis of religion. When a man takes this stand, he is on the way to find the truth, he is on the way to God. That determination must be the first impulse towards becoming religious. I will hew out a way for myself. I will know the truth or give up my life in the attempt. For on this side it is nothing, it is gone, it is vanishing every day. The beautiful, hopeful, young person of today is the veteran of tomorrow. Hopes and joys and pleasures will die like blossoms with tomorrow's frost. That is one side; on the other, there are the great charms of conquest, victories over all the ills of life, victory over life itself, the conquest of the universe. On that side men can stand. Those who dare, therefore, to struggle for victory, for truth, for religion, are in the right way; and that is what the Vedas preach: Be not in despair; the way is very difficult, like walking on the edge of a razor; yet despair not, arise, awake and find the ideal, the goal.

> उत्तिष्ठत जाग्रत प्राप्य वरान्निबोधत। क्षुरस्य धारा निशिता दुरत्यया पथस्तत्कवयो वदन्ति ॥१४॥
>
> *Arise! Awake! Approach the great and learn. Like the sharp edge of a razor is that path, so the wise say – hard to tread and difficult to cross.*

PART THREE

Freedom, the Goal of All Life

3

13 The Golden Thread in All Religions

¶13 Now all these various manifestations of religion, in whatever shape and form they have come to mankind, have this one common central basis. It is the preaching of freedom, the way out of the world. They never came to reconcile the world and religion, but to cut the Gordian knot, to establish religion in its own ideal and not to compromise with the world. That is what every religion preaches and the duty of the Vedanta is to harmonise all these aspirations, to make manifest the common ground between all the religions of the world, the highest as well as the lowest. What we call the most arrant superstition and the highest philosophy really have a common aim in that they both try to show the way out of the same difficulty and in most cases this way is through the help of someone who is not himself bound by the laws of nature, in one word, someone who is free. In spite of all the difficulties and differences of opinion about the nature of the one free agent, whether he is a Personal God or a sentient being like man, whether masculine, feminine or neuter – and the discussions have been endless – the fundamental idea is the same. In spite of the almost hopeless contradictions of the different systems, we find the golden thread of unity running through them all and in this philosophy, this golden thread has been traced, revealed little by little to our view and the first step to this revelation is the common ground that all are advancing towards freedom.

14 "In Freedom It Rises"

¶14 One curious fact present in the midst of all our joys and sorrows, difficulties and struggles, is that we are surely journeying towards freedom. The question was practically this: "What is this universe? From what does it arise? Into what does it go?" And the answer was: "In freedom it rises, in freedom it rests and into freedom it melts away." This idea of freedom you cannot relinquish. Your actions, your very lives will be lost without it. Every moment nature is proving us to be slaves and not free. Yet, simultaneously rises the other idea, that still we are free. At every step we are knocked down, as it were, by Maya and shown that we are

bound; and yet at the same moment, together with this blow, together with this feeling that we are bound, comes the other feeling that we are free. Some inner voice tells us that we are free. But if we attempt to realise that freedom, to make it manifest, we find the difficulties almost insuperable. Yet, in spite of that it insists on asserting itself inwardly, "I am free, I am free." And if you study all the various religions of the world you will find this idea expressed. Not only religion – you must not take this word in its narrow sense – but the whole life of society is the assertion of that one principle of freedom. All movements are the assertion of that one freedom. That voice has been heard by everyone, whether he knows it or not, that voice which declares, "Come unto Me all ye that labour and are heavy laden." It may not be in the same language or the same form of speech, but in some form or other, that voice calling for freedom has been with us. Yes, we are born here on account of that voice; every one of our movements is for that. We are all rushing towards freedom, we are all following that voice, whether we know it or not; as the children of the village were attracted by the music of the flute-player, so we are all following the music of the voice without knowing it.

15 All Creatures Follow the Voice

¶15 We are ethical when we follow that voice. Not only the human soul, but all creatures from the lowest to the highest have heard the voice and are rushing towards it; and in the struggle are either combining with each other or pushing each other out of the way. Thus come competition, joys, struggles, life, pleasure and death and the whole universe is nothing but the result of this mad struggle to reach the voice. This is the manifestation of nature.

16 When the Scene Shifts

¶16 What happens then? The scene begins to shift. As soon as you know the voice and understand what it is, the whole scene changes. The same world which was the ghastly battle-field of Maya is now changed into something good and beautiful. We no longer curse nature nor say that the world is horrible and that it is all vain; we need no longer weep and wail. As soon as we understand the voice, we see the reason why this struggle should be here, this fight, this competition, this difficulty, this cruelty, these little pleasures and joys; we see that they are in the nature of things, because without them there would be no going towards the voice, to attain which we are destined, whether we know it or not. All human life, all nature, therefore, is struggling to attain to freedom. The sun is moving towards the goal, so is the earth in circling round the sun, so is the moon encircling round the earth. To that goal the planet is moving and the air is blowing. Everything is struggling towards that. The saint is going towards that voice – he cannot help it, it is no glory to him. So is the sinner. The charitable man is going straight towards that voice and cannot be hindered; the miser is also going towards the same destination; the greatest worker of good hears the same voice within and he cannot resist it, he must go towards the voice; so with the most arrant idler. One stumbles more than another and him who stumbles more we call bad, him who stumbles less

we call good. Good and bad are never two different things, they are one and the same; the difference is not one of kind, but of degree.

17 Beings Beyond Nature: How the Idea of God Grows

¶17 Now, if the manifestation of this power of freedom is really governing the whole universe – applying that to religion, our special study – we find this idea has been the one assertion throughout. Take the lowest form of religion where there is worship of departed ancestors or certain powerful and cruel gods; what is the prominent idea about the gods or departed ancestors? That they are superior to nature, not bound by its restrictions. The worshipper has, no doubt, very limited ideas of nature. He himself cannot pass through a wall, nor fly up into the skies, but the gods whom he worships can do these things. What is meant by that, philosophically? That the assertion of freedom is there, that the gods whom he worships are superior to nature as he knows it. So with those who worship still higher beings. As the idea of nature expands, the idea of the soul which is superior to nature also expands, until we come to what we call monotheism, which holds that there is Maya (nature) and that there is some Being who is the Ruler of this Maya.

PART FOUR

The Vedantic Answer

4

18 Nearer, My God, to Me: Freedom Is Your Own Nature

¶18 Here Vedanta begins, where these monotheistic ideas first appear. But the Vedanta philosophy wants further explanation. This explanation – that there is a Being beyond all these manifestations of Maya, who is superior to and independent of Maya and who is attracting us towards Himself and that we are all going towards Him – is very good, says the Vedanta, but yet the perception is not clear, the vision is dim and hazy, although it does not directly contradict reason. Just as in your hymn it is said, "Nearer my God to Thee," the same hymn would be very good to the Vedantin, only he would change a word and make it, "Nearer my God to me." The idea that the goal is far off, far beyond nature, attracting us all towards it, has to be brought nearer and nearer, without degrading or degenerating it. The God of heaven becomes the God in nature and the God in nature becomes the God who is nature and the God who is nature becomes the God within this temple of the body and the God dwelling in the temple of the body at last becomes the temple itself, becomes the soul and man – and there it reaches the last words it can teach. He whom the sages have been seeking in all these places is in our own hearts; the voice that you heard was right, says the Vedanta, but the direction you gave to the voice was wrong. That ideal of freedom that you perceived was correct, but you projected it outside yourself and that was your mistake. Bring it nearer and

nearer, until you find that it was all the time within you, it was the Self of your own self. That freedom was your own nature and this Maya never bound you. Nature never has power over you. Like a frightened child you were dreaming that it was throttling you and the release from this fear is the goal: not only to see it intellectually, but to perceive it, actualise it, much more definitely than we perceive this world. Then we shall know that we are free. Then and then alone, will all difficulties vanish, then will all the perplexities of heart be smoothed away, all crookedness made straight, then will vanish the delusion of manifoldness and nature; and Maya, instead of being a horrible, hopeless dream, as it is now, will become beautiful and this earth, instead of being a prison-house, will become our playground; and even dangers and difficulties, even all sufferings, will become deified and show us their real nature, will show us that behind everything, as the substance of everything, He is standing and that He is the one real Self.

WORDS AND REFERENCES

Glossary

Maya
A central idea of Vedanta. It does not mean the world is nothing at all. It names the way the one Reality appears to us as a changing world of many things, and the contradictory way we experience life: seeking happiness where it cannot last, feeling free yet bound. In this lecture Vivekananda shows Maya through everyday examples rather than defining it.

Vedanta
The philosophy based on the Upanishads, the concluding portion of the Vedas. Its central teaching is that the true Self of every being is one with the infinite Reality (Brahman).

Vedas
The most ancient scriptures of India, regarded in the tradition as revealed knowledge.

Katha Upanishad
One of the principal Upanishads, the dialogue between the boy Nachiketa and Yama, the lord of death. The verse quoted in ¶12 (1.3.14) begins "Arise! Awake!"

Self (Atman)
Our real nature, pure consciousness, distinct from body and mind. Vedanta teaches that this Self is ever free and one with God.

Narada
A sage and great devotee in Hindu tradition, often shown travelling the worlds singing the name of God.

Krishna
Revered in Hindu tradition as an incarnation of God, and the teacher of the Bhagavad Gita.

"This My Maya is divine…"
Bhagavad Gita 7.14: the divine Maya, made of the three qualities (gunas), is hard to cross, but those who take refuge in God cross over it.

Buddha and the Bo-tree
Gautama, the Buddha, sat under the Bodhi (Bo) tree resolved not to rise until he attained enlightenment, resisting every temptation to return to his former life.

Monotheism
Belief in one God who rules over nature.

Gordian knot
From Greek legend: an impossibly tangled knot that Alexander the Great simply cut through. It means solving a problem decisively instead of untangling it bit by bit.

"Trailing clouds of glory"
A line from William Wordsworth's poem "Ode: Intimations of Immortality", suggesting the soul comes into the world from a divine source.

"Come unto Me…"
The words of Jesus in the Gospel of Matthew 11:28.

"Still small voice"
A phrase from the Bible (1 Kings 19:12), where God speaks to the prophet Elijah not in wind, earthquake or fire, but in a quiet voice.

"Nearer, my God, to Thee"
A well-known Christian hymn (Sarah Flower Adams, 1841). Vivekananda playfully turns it into "Nearer my God to me."

The flute-player
The Pied Piper of Hamelin, from the old German legend, whose music drew the children of the town to follow him.

VEDANTA AND MODERN UNDERSTANDING

Bridge to Wellbeing

Vivekananda spoke as a teacher of Vedanta, not a scientist, yet several of his observations have interesting echoes in modern psychology. These parallels do not prove the spiritual teaching; they show that his description of the human condition is one that careful observers keep rediscovering.

A MODERN LENS

The moth and the flame (¶4)

Psychologists describe hedonic adaptation: after a gain or a loss, people tend to drift back towards their usual level of happiness, so each new pleasure soon feels ordinary. Neuroscience also distinguishes "wanting" from "liking": the brain systems that drive craving can grow stronger even when the pleasure itself does not. That is close to his picture of returning "again and again with freshened energy."

A MODERN LENS

A mother's love (¶7)

Much of our emotional life runs on conditioned responses and attachment patterns that operate below conscious choice. Vivekananda's point is honest seeing: what we call love may also contain compulsion. This is not advice to remain in harm's way. Freedom, in Vedanta, includes the strength to set boundaries, and anyone in a harmful relationship deserves support from trusted people or professionals.

A MODERN LENS

Covering the wound (¶10)

Research on emotion regulation suggests that habitually suppressing feelings tends to go with poorer wellbeing than reappraising them honestly. Acceptance-based therapies likewise invite people to face difficult experience openly. Both resonate with his warning that sores hidden under cloth of gold do not heal.

A MODERN LENS

Dissatisfaction as a beginning (¶12)

Models of behaviour change describe a stage of honest recognition ("contemplation") that comes before real change. Vivekananda's "tremendous dissatisfaction" is not despair: it is joined to the hopeful command "Arise! Awake!"

A MODERN LENS

Freedom within (¶18)

Contemplative practices train us to observe thoughts and feelings rather than be driven by them, what psychologists call decentering. Vedanta goes much further, teaching that the witnessing Self was never bound. Even a small taste of this inner distance can ease anxiety and restore choice.

FOR REVISION AND REFLECTION

Questions

1 UNDERSTAND

Name four of the "faces" of Maya Vivekananda describes in Part One. Why do you think he repeats "And this is Maya" instead of giving a definition?

2 UNDERSTAND

What are the two responses to suffering he describes in Part Two? Why does he say the "practical" one must always fail?

3 REFLECT

Narada lived twelve years in half an hour and forgot his Master's errand. Recall a time when a worry, a plan or a story in your mind absorbed you completely. What helped you come back to the present?

4 APPLY

Choose one pleasure you return to "with freshened energy" though it never fully satisfies. This week, when you feel its pull, pause for three breaths before acting. What do you notice?

5 REFLECT

In the mother passage, love and compulsion are mixed together. Where in your own relationships do you see this? How might you care for someone more freely, without giving up love and without accepting harm?

6 APPLY

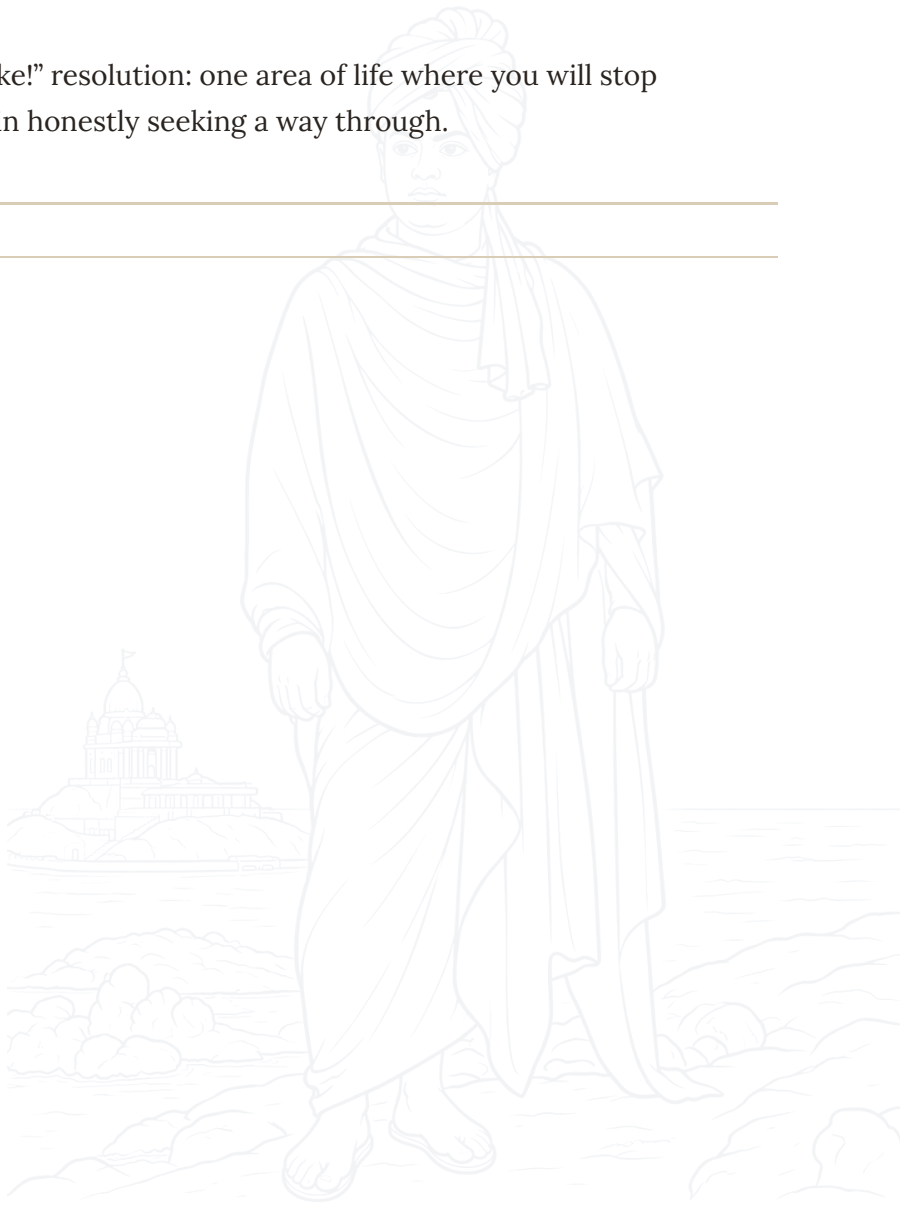
Vivekananda says good and bad differ "not one of kind, but of degree." How could this change the way you respond to someone who hurts you, or to your own mistakes?

7 UNDERSTAND AND REFLECT

Explain the change from "Nearer my God to Thee" to "Nearer my God to me." On a difficult day, what difference would it make to remember that freedom is your own nature?

8 APPLY

Write your own "Arise! Awake!" resolution: one area of life where you will stop patching things up and begin honestly seeking a way through.





RAMAKRISHNA VEDANTA CENTRE NZ

Vedanta Lectures of Swami Vivekananda

Ritam Courses · Study of Vivekananda Lectures

vedanta.nz